

Mitsue Kanko (Forest Co-op) — Meeting 5 Aug 2026

Advance questions sent to the co-op, for their preparation

(English reference copy of `mitsue_kanko_meeting_prep_questions_jp.md`, the document actually sent.)

Thank you for agreeing to meet with us on August 5th.

To make the most of our time together, we wanted to share in advance the topics we'd like to discuss. There's no need to have firm answers ready for all of this — a general sense of direction is enough. We just wanted you to have a chance to think about it beforehand.

Guiding principle (sharing this first)

The purpose of replanting is ecosystem restoration — restoring the forest as a food source for wildlife — not short-term timber profit. More Trees, who have the expertise, will select the species; we'd be glad for the co-op to handle planting and tending.

1. Understanding what you do today

- What forestry work do you currently carry out (thinning, afforestation, processing, sales)?
- Do you already have experience or techniques for native broadleaf reforestation, or has your experience so far been mainly with sugi?
 - Experience with **local-provenance seedlings** (seed-collected and grown in the village, replanted on the same land)?
 - Experience with **assisted natural regeneration** (tending existing seedlings rather than planting)?
 - Familiarity with, or experience trying, **natural species arrangement** or Miyawaki-style dense planting?
- What's your current capacity — chippers, operators, crew availability?

2. Chip production (supply chain)

- Would thinning be done by the co-op, by private contractors, or a mix of both?
- What's your thinking on equipment — owned, rented, or contracted?
- Can you meet the CHP's chip sizing standard (P31S / P45, roughly 30–50 mm)?
- Any thoughts on the transport route from forest to the processing/storage site?

3. Drying & storage

- Who would you envision handling the drying of green chips?
- Would you prefer the drying/storage site co-located with the CHP, or a separate satellite site on the forest side?
- Anything we should confirm regarding fire safety or permitting for chip storage?

4. Role & relationship with the co-op

- Which feels like the right fit for the co-op's role here — partner, contractor, or something in between?

- Any interest in planting and tending native broadleaf trees (species selected by More Trees) for wildlife forage?
- Any interest in co-running the seedling/nursery work as a school or eco-tourism programme?
- Would a profit-sharing model or a service-fee arrangement be more realistic for the co-op?

5. Land & contracts

- Could you help with an inventory of landowners for the parcels involved?
- Is there any village-owned forest land usable without private contracts?
- Would you be open to setting up a formal body (something like a landowner liaison association) to handle contact and agreements between parcel landowners and the co-op for this project?
- We understand the co-op is already contracted by the village for the 施業放置林整備事業 (neglected-forest thinning programme, financed by the Forest Environment Transfer Tax, run at a 40% thinning rate). How much of your current crew/equipment capacity is tied up in that work, and how much could be freed up — or added — for our reforestation work?
- Village council records put village-wide neglected forest (放置林) at approximately 2,600 ha. Does that match your own internal figures? Is any of it already in the areas we're targeting?
- On recent clear-cut sites, there's currently no legal requirement to replant, and the village can only "encourage" it. Even without a legal mandate, would the co-op be open to making native-broadleaf replanting a standard practice on the clear-cuts you handle?

6. AI data center & biomass — the new-workforce angle

The CHP's biomass fuel demand and the AI data center concept are meant to act as a "pull" to help grow the co-op's crew over time.

- Does year-round CHP fuel demand (versus seasonal thinning) look like a basis for offering stable, full-time forestry jobs?
- Would a guaranteed biomass chip offtake (fixed volume and price) give you the confidence to hire and train new crew?
- Realistically, how many additional crew could you take on and train per year?
- Would you be open to the energy project funding mechanization (harvesters, chippers) to raise per-worker output?
- Would you prefer to employ relocated/newly-recruited workers directly under the co-op, or a joint arrangement / secondment?
- Do you think the "reforest → power AI compute → revive the village" story would help with your own recruitment and retention?
- Any concerns that outside-funded growth might change the co-op's character or members' control over it?

For reference: Tenkawa × More Trees precedent

Tenkawa Village and the Dorogawa Property Ward (洞川財産区) signed a forest conservation agreement with More Trees (Sakamoto Ryuichi himself) on 2021-06-07, still active as of 2025. About 6 ha of former ski-resort clear-cut land was replanted with native broadleaf (キハダ), 3,000+ trees over three years, funded by corporate sponsors. The co-op handled planting and tending; the NGO handled fundraising. We mention this as a working example of this exact model already succeeding in a comparable Nara mountain village.

The goal for the day is not to reach conclusions on all of this — just to hear your thinking and see where a good working arrangement might take shape. Happy to answer any questions in advance if useful.

Related docs

- Japanese (sent to co-op): `mitsue_kanko_meeting_prep_questions_jp.md`
- Full internal question list: `meeting_mitsue_kanko_2026-08-05.md`